city of Dholavira in Gujarat, for example, is 771 metres by 617 metres. Over a thousand years later, the same ratio appears in Hindu texts like the *Shatapatha Brahmana* and *Shulbha Sutra* that use the ratio in their precise instructions on how to build fire-altars for Vedic ceremonies.[4]

Another millennium later we find the same ratio mentioned in the vastu shastra texts (these texts are still used in the same way the Chinese use feng shui). In the sixth century AD, the great scholar Varahamihira states that a king's palace should be built such that the length is greater than the breadth by a quarter. The Iron Pillar of Delhi mentioned earlier is also designed in the same ratio: the overall length of the pillar is 7.67 metres while the section above the ground is 6.12 metres, a ratio of 5:4.

It is obvious that this ratio was considered special for a very long time. So when the seventeenth-century Mughal emperor Aurangzeb wanted to praise his vassal Maharaja Jai Singh, he called him 'Sawai' (meaning that he was worth a quarter more than any other man). This title was used by Jai Singh's descendants till the kingdom of Jaipur was absorbed into the Indian Republic. Even today, a tourist visiting Jaipur will see a small flag fluttering above the old royal flag—it's the extra quarter—a reminder of the old town planners of Dholavira. It is appropriate, therefore, that Jai Singh is remembered mostly for the town planning of the city of Jaipur.

Not all the continuities of Indian history are linear. Some of them are circular. The Jews came to India as traders and refugees in the first century AD and settled along the southwestern coast. Almost two thousand years later, their descendants would return to the modern state of Israel. Similarly, Arabs traders came to India in the Middle Ages to seek their fortune. From the 1970s, their descendants, the Moplahs of Kerala, would return in large numbers to the oil. rich Arab states to work for their distant cousins. Most interesting of all was the fate of the Timurid dynasty, better known as the Mughals. In the fourteenth century, Taimur the Lame would capture Delhi and massacre its inhabitants in the tens of thousands. His direct descendant, the last Mughal emperor Bahadur Shah Zafar, would watch helplessly as the British sacked Delhi in 1858 and put his sons to death.